Inspired by China
AN INTERVIEW WITH YEUNG CHAN

BY JOHN LAVINE



PHOTO BY DEAN POWELL, COUTESY OF PEABODY ESSEX MUSEUM

On October 28, 2006, *Inspired by China: Contemporary Furnituremakers Explore Chinese Traditions*, will open at the Peabody Essex Museum in Salem, Massachusetts. The exhibition brings together approximately 30 examples of historic Chinese furniture and new works designed by 21 furnituremakers from around the world whose response to China's rich and varied furniture traditions will reveal the creative power of cross-cultural exchange. Last winter I talked with northern California furnituremaker Yeung Chan when he was still in the early stages of building a pair of chairs and a table for the show.

JL: Yeung, I've seen your furniture for a number of years now—it was a piece of classical Chinese seating furniture that I first saw, and we did an article for Woodwork *magazine [**October 1998**]. Since then, I've seen other furniture pieces of yours that also adhere pretty closely to that look. So I was so startled to see how far your pieces for the* Inspired by China *show have evolved away from that style. Will you talk about how you came to this much more contemporary look?*

YC: I was born in China, and grew up there until I was 22 years old. So I always saw Chinese furniture. Then I came to the United States and I worked for a furniture company, and in my daily life as well I saw mostly Western-style furniture, both 18th century and modern. And I like them all. On one side, I admire this Chinese culture—the joinery technique, some of the design detail. But then on the other side, I also like the very simple lines of contemporary furniture, a perfect fit for modern life. I think that people feel Chinese furniture is antique. For example, the chairs usually have a very hard seat, and everything's upright, and you can not just sit on it. So I had this thought several years ago, since I like some Chinese furniture, to maintain the sound joinery structure, but make it simple and comfortable, more fit to modern daily life in a modern house. So in my mind, I was already trying to design some furniture along this direction. Now, the Peabody Essex Museum has created this special project, *Inspired By China*, and invited me to participate, and I said to myself, this is perfect timing.

JL: When I first looked at your design, there were elements that reminded me of classical Ming furniture—the cloud-lift, and some other lines that I've come to recognize.

But on the other hand, it reminds me of Danish Modern furniture and Scandinavian design, which evolved out of another strong wood culture. Can you talk about some of the other kinds of furniture that you like?

YC: My most favorite furniture designer, especially among chairmakers, is Hans Wegner, a Danish designer. Many years ago, I first saw his chair, the 1943 design simply titled "The Chair," which I liked at first sight and still admire today. It's simple, it's functional, it's beautiful. And that gave me lots to think about.

*JL: A lot of people don't realize when they look at some contemporary furniture that they're often seeing the influences of China there. When you showed me some of the pictures from your books of Chinese furniture [**see Looking Back, p.80**], I really understood for the first time how much Western furniture styles have borrowed from the Chinese. Tell me more about how you first imagined this chair, and then the various stages it went through.*

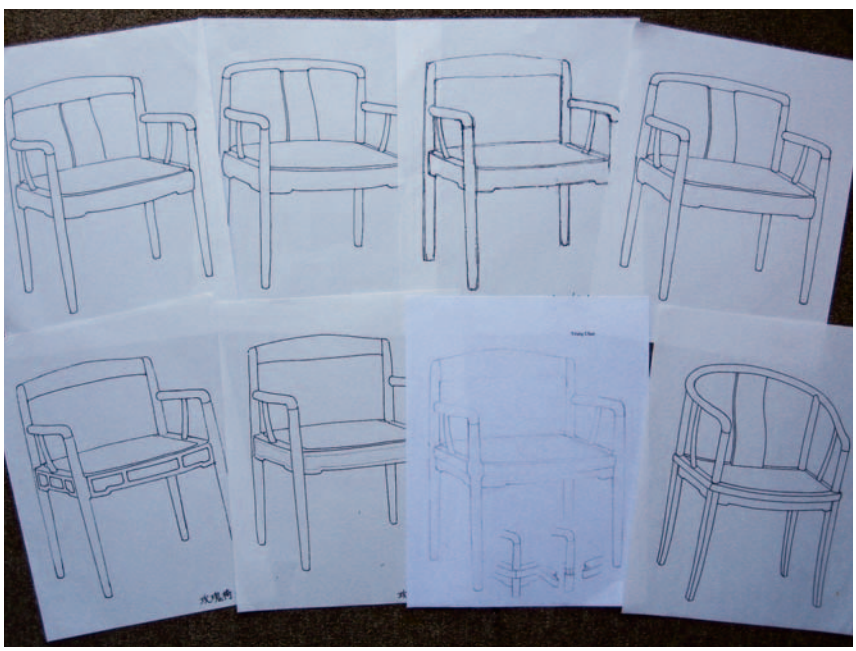
YC: Okay. You look at a chair, any chair, especially a dining chair or a side chair: It's four legs, either with arms or without arms, a back support, a seat panel. And that's it. From there, you make all different kinds of designs. Looking at Chinese traditional styles, you have the "Low Back Southern-Official's Hat Chair"—that the name, literally translated from the Chinese to English. Another style is called an "Intellectual's Chair" or "Scholar's Chair." These chairs look heavy, and are usually next to a desk or put right next to the window for reading or writing. I want to make this chair for daily use, so I don't want to make it heavy. There is another style, called "Rose Chair," which is generally smaller than the others. This is what I chose to start my design.

And a Chinese chair has many, many rails. The arm, the middle rail, and the bottom rail all work to make the chair, in a way, very strong. But on the outside, very heavy and very clumsy, so I tried to eliminate some, but at the same time, I have to maintain the strength. So, looking at the finished design, I stopped it there. But also, I don't want to lose the Chinese traditional part, so I adopt some of the Chinese details. Like the curved arm, which goes out to the front and joins with the front leg, then, right in the middle of the arm, there's a vertical rail connecting the arm to the side rail. That's a very traditional Chinese chair detail. And all this, I want to keep, because this not only makes the chair strong, but also makes the chair look good, and also gives the Chinese character.

Other thinking that went into the design—a Chinese chair traditionally used some darker wood, like *zitan* [*Pterocarpus sp.*] or *huanghuali* [*Dalbergia odorifera*]. They are traditionally pretty dark colors, either darker brown or burgundy red colors. On the other hand, the West nowadays uses cherry, maple, mahogany, oak, which in general are lighter-colored woods. So, thinking about the material for this design, I tried not to use the dark-colored woods like traditional Chinese furniture uses. But also, I don't want to use light-colored wood for this chair. So right now my choice is to use cherry, which is a light color and dark color—right in the middle.

Another thing I want to mention is the seat. In traditional Chinese furniture, the chair has a seat that is made of hardwood. That is quite often in southern Chinese furniture. In a northern Chinese chair, they either have a hardwood seat or they have a cane seat to make it soft. Those are the two different styles. Quite often, for the hardwood seat, people put a pad or cushion on top of the seat. Still, this gives a very stiff feeling when you sit on it. That's why Chinese chairs in general are not very comfortable to sit on. My thinking in this area is that I can bring a change. My approach is, I use a piece of plywood seat, and then put a half-inch of high-density foam, and fabric or leather to cover. This will give a soft, comfortable feeling, but not very soft, that's my thinking. And I hope it will work.

Trying to find a look that is contemporary yet has traditional Chinese character; here are some of the sketches of different possibilities.



Starting from the basic size and form of a Chinese "Rose Chair" (33" x 22" x 24"), I tape cardboard cut-outs onto a first mock-up.



PHOTOS BY YEUNG CHAN EXCEPT AS NOTED







Shaping the legs for the chairs; a router fixture makes the process easy and accurate.

I use a similar fixture, with the addition of stops, to rout the mortises in the leg parts.

Pattern-shaping the side rails. The rail ends have already been mortised and shaped to fit the legs.

JL: The legs of the chair are canted in and back, and yet the arms, the vertical supports and the back have this fullness to them, of being bowed out, so there's a lot of movement. You've shown me several different patterns for the curve of those armrests. After you come up with an initial design for that, and then make a mock-up, how do you then make these little changes? What are you thinking about, what are you looking at?

YC: Interesting. I make things—either a full piece of furniture or even hand tools—for people. Of course, in design, I believe there are certain rules you need to follow. But then, on the other side, you just cannot follow the rules all the time. If everybody followed the same design rules, then everything that came out would be so close to everything else that it loses its specialness. I design things—again, first, with a purpose. A chair is going to be used to sit on, but also I want to make it look nice, same as any other furniture. Make it look good, and good to use, are these two important elements. So when I first decided the size of this chair, then I read many, many Chinese furniture books and looked at their drawings. From there I have some idea in my mind, so I just get a piece of cardboard and draw it. And it comes out, I put it on and see if it's good. If I come up to the point where I'm happy, then I make a mock-up, to make it three-dimensional, to really look at it. Then from there, there are many, many changes. So I keep cutting cardboard and putting it on, back and forth, back and forth, many, many times and many, many changes. Then at a point, I come up with something I like, but that's not necessarily what everybody likes. So I will consult some good friends and ask them, what do you think? I think this is the one, I like it the best, what do you think? And then let them see all the previous cardboard mockups. But interestingly, often the one I like is what most people like also. Still, you cannot please everyone. Maybe someone says, oh, I don't like it, I liked the very first one. But then, when most people like the last one, the last one will be fine and will be the good one. And I very much trust the—what do you call it—the feeling I have myself. I can tell, it looks good to you, and I'm not saying I'm the only one involved in designing this, but quite often I make something out the way I think is right, and most people will like it. So far, so good.

JL: None of the chair parts are square, and nothing is simply turned on a lathe…how do you do the shaping?

YC: This mock-up piece, that's easy, because it's not very critical, the mock-up being just to give a three-dimensional, full-scale look. I cut the wood on a tablesaw, give it dimension, or on a bandsaw. Then I use a spokeshave, very quickly, set up the cutting very roughly, to round it, to give it a quick look. It seems a lot of work, but then when you have a good tool, it is not really that hard. Also, the wood is pretty soft in this case. For Chinese furniture, *zitan* or *huanghuali*, that is a different story. Those would be hard, and probably take more time to do. But still, hand tools will take care of most of the job. That's what I do. Then in making the final chair, I have a simple setup. I use a router like a milling machine to rough-cut the four legs in a pretty round shape. Also, it's not even a uniform diameter—it's smaller on both ends and then bigger in the middle, which I really like, that little detail. It makes a chair very modern looking and very lightweight. It just pleases the eye, with the whole design. The idea of using the router to cut the legs, it just speeds it up. So the arm probably still uses the spokeshave, rout it after the bandsaw cut. I did it many times in some other furniture, so I know how to do it and I am confident doing that part. The only thing at this point I'm not quite sure of, don't have a final solution to yet, is the back support to the rear leg, the rear area where they join. I still need to deal with







The completed leg-rail connection.

Determining the armrest curve. After trying out dozens of shapes, I made a master pattern from the best-looking design.

Drilling holes for the dowels that will join the front legs to the armrests.

that area because it's very hard to realize the angle of the back, how it joins to the back leg. Of course, the joint itself will be a dowel or a loose tenon, that's the way to go, but what I am talking about is the angle from the back center to both ends of the back rail to the rear leg top. I need to make a mock-up to get a good look and then work from there. Any other area, I believe I'm pretty happy with now.

JL: Will that back splat be a bent lamination or will you make it out of solid stock?

YC: Traditionally, the backs of Chinese chairs—actually, all the Chinese furniture back in the Ming dynasty—no matter how big a curve, were all cut from solid wood. So I have two options here. One, I can cut from a heavy piece of solid cherry to create the back, like a sculptured piece, or I can slice some veneer, about 1/8"-thick cherry veneer, and put it onto a mold to form the curve. You don't really have a clear advantage or disadvantage either way. Solid wood is traditional, but you will use lots of wood. Lamination, you use less wood. The other difference of the two is the way the grain shows on the surface, facing the front. If you cut from solid wood, you cut into the grain and you break the grain pattern. If it's a lamination, you can see the wood grain follow the curve. But when you look at the edge, you can see the lamination line. This might be okay for modern furniture. I haven't decided what to do yet. I don't even know if I can find anything thick enough—at least 12/4 cherry. That will cost money. So from a production point of view, that's not economical, and the lamination would be a good way to go.

JL: Will you talk a little bit about the table that's going with the chairs?

YC: The table. Right now, I am still pretty much focused on the chairs, because the chairs have a lot more parts. If you look at a table, there's a table top and then the support. That's a table. In this case, when I make a table to match this chair, my idea is to make two chairs, a pair, and then a table right in the middle, to make it as a good setting for the presentation. To give the idea of a set of furniture—I always believe one single chair, especially an armchair or side chair, it just doesn't go anywhere. A chair looks good only if it comes as a set, a pair and a table in the middle, or a set of chair and table as a dining table, dining room set. It makes it look good. A single chair only looks good when it is a rocking chair, a stool. A side chair by itself—it just doesn't go anywhere. So because the chair I'm designing—the table will use the same style



The seat panel is laminated from 6 pieces of 1/8" birch plywood and bent over a form.



A small crack in the wood can be fixed with a plug, carefully selected for grain and epoxied in place.



Working on the joint between the back top rail and rear leg—fine shaping with a knife.



Holes drilled and dowels cut, ready for glue-up of the back splat to the back top rail.



The rasp removes wood quickly but leaves heavy cut marks; I use it only for coarse shaping.



Cutting cherry veneers for the table top panel.



The completed joinery for the frame-and-panel table top: a mitered mortise-and-tenon. The top will be shaped after glue-up.

of posts, the legs, like the chair legs. And then they will carry the little detail of the curved lamination. Then the top. For the top I have two options. One is a solid top, another one is a frame, and inside, a piece of glass as a top. The glass would really give the table a very contemporary look. Back in the old days, again, glass was invented in the West and then introduced to China in the late 18th century, I believe. Before that, all Chinese furniture, the top was either wood or marble, that kind of material. So this one, I am debating using a piece of glass on it in a frame, then four legs, and underneath the glass this wooden shelf—a kind of coffee table. I haven't decided yet. The table style—the leg will be just like the chair legs. It's very simple. Simple and clean, so this is what's in my mind, and I haven't gotten into the details yet. Relatively simple, I say now. The chairs are more complicated and take more thinking.

JL: It surprises me that you'd think about glass for the top. You're really experimenting—you're talking about leather upholstery on the chairs, glass on the table….

YC: Yeah. Again, my goal is, I want anyone to say, "oh yeah, that's a nice little chair, looks simple and looks comfortable." When people buy things for themselves, the basic question is, will this look good in my house? Hopefully they will say, oh, yeah, this is the style I like, and this will fit into my house in the living room, in the study room, anywhere. So leather and glass are very common materials for furniture, and they are good. A leather seat would be durable. The glass is good because you can put magazines or something on the shelf, and you can see it through the glass top. My thinking, again, is to design furniture that is meant for use, not just to be looked at. If I make a table really high-class, with veneer and polished glass, very shiny, then when you use it, you have to be extremely careful. You are afraid to scratch it, you are afraid to ding the surface, you are afraid the coffee, the tea, or whatever will stain the beautiful surface, or even scratch the beautiful finish. All these things make the tabletop not a very practical thing to use, but good to look at. So to avoid that, glass is a very good choice—you can put hot coffee on top, you can put cold iced soda on top, and even if water spills on it, you just wipe it off and dry it and it's fine, you won't get any damage. But this veneer…just forget about water: it will eventually get into the finish and cause all kinds of trouble, and that's not something every ordinary family can easily take care of. That's my thinking. Practical thinking.

JL: Very practical. That reminds me, what kind of finish do you think you'll put on it?

YC: Shellac. It has a long history as a finish for furniture. In my shop, I also spray lacquer, would be another way to go, but I prefer shellac. It's easier to apply and also easier for people to take care of, so it's one of my favorite finishes.

JL: Will you apply it like a French polish?

YC: Just regular—wipe it on and then let it dry, and then put about three or four coats. It will keep a nice shiny look, and smooth. Yeah. So I like it, especially, again, here, because the wood I picked is cherry, and cherry is really good with shellac. It's just excellent. Some other wood, like oak or even walnut, an oil finish is perfectly good. But for cherry, shellac does beautifully. This is all based on all these years of making furniture from the ideal that this chair comes out of, to the material used for the chair, the leather seat, the glass top for the table, and on and on. All those things don't just come overnight. Those come after making many, many pieces of furniture, and then coming to this conclusion. So far, the final thinking.